

BODY / NOT BODY

A Simulation of Self

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Abstract

This paper presents *BODY / NOT BODY*, a durational performance installation in which the artist engages in a two-hour unscripted conversation with a real-time, AI-driven simulation of himself. The work explores whether and how human identity can be simulated using AI in 2025. Audience members submit text prompts that the performer is required to speak aloud to the simulation, provoking responses that loop between human and digital self. While initially conceived as a technical challenge, the scope rather expanded as things developed into a larger exploration of philosophical questions surrounding the fluidity of identity, who we are to ourselves and others, the impossibility of being objective about oneself, technical gaps and the truths they expose, and how little might be needed in the space of an interaction to effectively evoke at least the gist of one's identity. Through iterative prototyping combining voice cloning, fine-tuned large language models (LLMs), and a custom avatar, the project reveals that the gaps, failures, and uncanny moments in AI-driven self-simulation are often more revealing and meaningful than perfect mimicry.

Ccs Concepts

• Human-centered computing • Human computer interaction (HCI); • Computing methodologies • Artificial intelligence; • Applied computing • Performing arts;

Keywords

Artificial Intelligence, Human-Computer Interaction, Performance Art, Digital Identity, Voice Cloning, Large Language Models, Simulation, Real-time Interaction

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1. Introduction

The central question guiding this work is: To what extent can human identity be convincingly simulated using current AI technologies? Conceived initially as a technical challenge, the project evolved into a durational performance installation interrogating identity, self-perception, and the fluidity of the digital self. The culminating performance involves the artist in dialogue with a simulated version of himself while audience members submit prompts to shape the interaction. This paper documents the conceptual framework, design process, technical implementation, and insights gleaned from the project.

2. Background & Related Work

The work draws on critical theories of simulation, performativity, and digital identity. Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* describes the creation of "operational doubles" that offer "all the signs of the real," a notion central to the project. Goffman's theories of social performance resonate with the recognition that identity is inherently contextual and performative.

Related digital projects, such as Eugenia Kuyda's chatbot memorializing her deceased friend and Etsuko Ichihara's Digital Shaman Project, informed early conceptual development. These works, often rooted in grief and memory, sparked reflection on whether digital self-simulations could serve purposes beyond posthumous connection—such as fostering self-awareness or therapeutic reflection.

Contemporary discourse on online identity, including Maya Man's observations on performativity in digital spaces, underscored the notion that any self-simulation is inherently performative and contingent on context. The project also draws from emerging studies on AI-driven therapy, people falling in love

with ChatGPT, and the psychological impacts of conversational agents.



Figure 1: Image of BODY / NOT BODY live durational performance installation. The live artist and digital simulation side by side.

3. Design & Implementation

3.1 Technical Approach

The simulation integrates three core components: a custom-fine-tuned large language model (LLM) using the OpenAI API, a voice clone created with ElevenLabs, and a digital avatar constructed in Unreal Engine. The initial prototype was built in TouchDesigner using OpenAI's Whisper for speech-to-text, ElevenLabs for text-to-speech, and GPT-3.5 Turbo as the 'brain' for conversational AI.

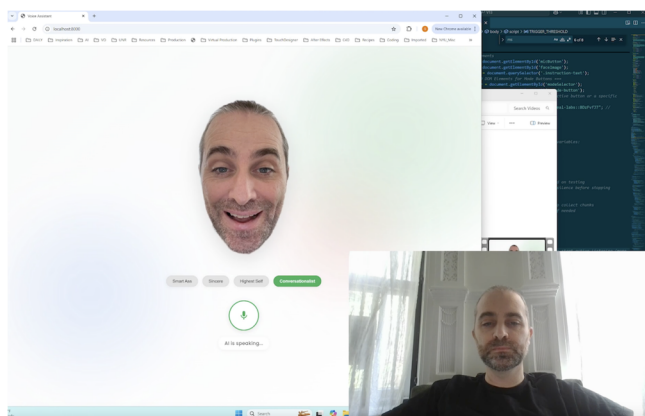


Figure 2: Early browser-based voice-to-voice prototype with Modes of Self functionality.

Finding TouchDesigner limiting, the system was rebuilt as a browser-based prototype allowing for faster iteration and integration of fine-tuned LLMs. The artist created multiple "modes of self"—including smart-ass, sincere, highest self, and conversationalist—by fine-tuning different models using custom

datasets. These modes were informed by a user poll collecting descriptors of the artist's communication style and worldview.

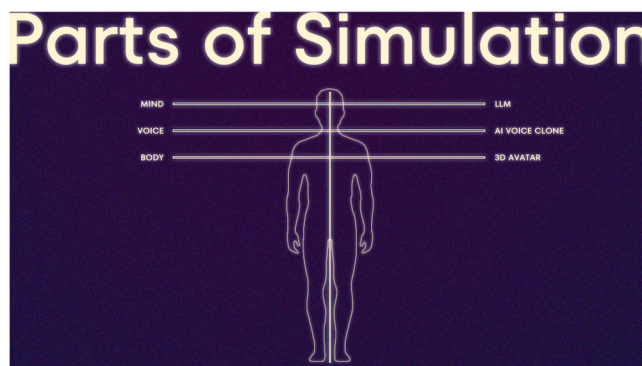


Figure 3: Diagram of parts making up the simulation.

3.2 Avatar Development

The avatar component proved particularly challenging. Initial attempts to create a custom Metahuman in Unreal Engine failed to produce a recognizable likeness. A more successful approach involved using a Polycam 3D scan of the artist's head, composited onto a pre-existing avatar body within Unreal. Despite technical limitations, the visual representation added a critical layer of embodiment to the simulation.

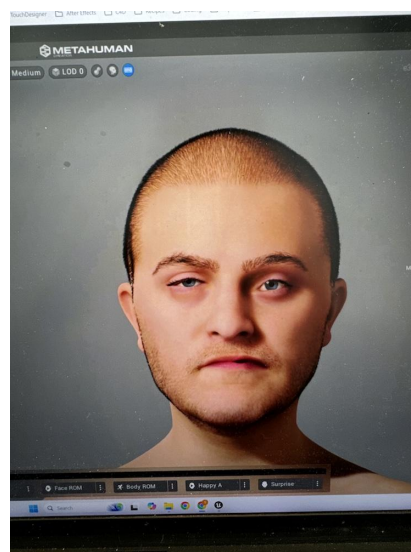


Figure 4: Initial failure using UnrealEngine Metahumans to create avatar.



Figure 5: Final avatar iteration created using Polycam, Blender and UnrealEngine.

3.3 Performance Interface

The final prototype allowed for real-time voice-to-voice conversation with the simulated self. Audience members submitted prompts via a websockets-based interface, which the performer was required to speak aloud, regardless of content, before the AI-generated response was delivered.

4. Performance Installation

The culminating public performance took place in a pitch black darkened space where the only thing visible was the artist standing beside a life-sized digital avatar of himself, separated from the audience by a one-way mirror. Viewers could see the artist, but the artist, on the other side of the one-way mirror, could only see the reflection of himself and his simulation. Over two hours, the artist held continuous dialogue with the simulation, responding to both the AI's outputs and live audience submissions.

This performative frame emphasized the artificiality and theatricality of identity. The requirement that the artist speak audience submissions aloud created moments of vulnerability, humor, and estrangement. The audience became complicit in shaping the self-representation, transforming the performance into a collective act of identity co-creation.

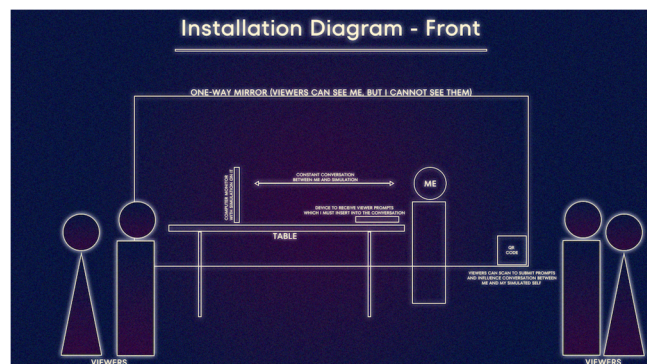


Figure 6.

5. Evaluation & Reflection

User testing revealed divergent responses. Early testers, including family members, displayed discomfort or confusion, while later interactions, including with the artist's young daughter, highlighted the playful and surreal qualities of the simulation. The most compelling interactions were often those that broke the illusion—moments when the AI failed or responded unpredictably.

Feedback gathered through a structured user poll was used to train the LLM to communicate like the artist, and further highlighted the multiplicity of perceived selves, underscoring the impossibility of creating a singular, "accurate" simulation. The responses emphasized that identity is always context-dependent and relational.

Crucially, the project revealed that factual accuracy or long-term memory were less important than the tone and feeling of the interaction. The sensation of being "understood"—even by an imperfect mirror—proved to be the affective core of the experience.

6. Conclusion & Future Work

BODY / NOT BODY demonstrates that while current AI tools cannot produce flawless self-simulations, they can evoke powerful reflections on identity, performance, and the boundaries of selfhood. The project's iterative process highlighted the value of imperfection, humor, and failure in creating meaningful digital experiences.

Future directions include exploring therapeutic applications of self-simulation, refining real-time performance systems, and further investigating the performative nature of digital identity. The work contributes to ongoing discourse on human-computer interaction, AI-mediated performance, and posthuman embodiment.

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